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Islam and clan organization among the Hausa

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THE EFFECTS OF CONVERSION ON THE CLAN SYSTEM

Material from such half-assimilated recent converts will be utilized here insofar as it illuminates the course of events which leads to the extinction of clan structures among the fully assimilated. The situation is, of course, not fully comparable to that of the early mass conversions which set the pattern of suppression of clan organization, a pattern now fully established, to which the converts from the present minority of pagans gradually conform.

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Among those groups whose conversion took place two or three generations ago the clan still survives. In answer to the question 'ina 'i rinka? "What is your kind?" to which the pagan Hausa answers with either his tribal name, e.g. Kutumbawa or Katsinawa or his clan name, these converts also answer with either a tribal name or their clan name. The kira ri verse, though no longer employed at births or marriages, is known to some individuals. Though the clan name is known, the clan itself is divested of practically all its functions, as will be evident from the material to be presented.

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One of the most striking differences between the clans of the recent converts and of the pagan Hausa is that the former are no longer exogamous; marriage within the clan is allowed, though not required. The pagan cross-cousin marriage is replaced by the favored Moslem form of parallel-cousin marriage between the children of two brothers. The loss of clan exogamy is everywhere found immediately after conversion and is one of its first effects. A pagan explaining what would be involved in his conversion said that he would now consider his parallel cousins as 'abo kan wa sa, "joking relatives," and marry

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his former clan mates. Although the association between joking relationship and marriage is only found in the case of cross-cousins of opposite sex, it will be seen that the association is so strong that once parallel cousins begin to marry, they are said to be in a joking relationship. This is only a passing phase, since among the Moslem Hausa as a whole, cross-cousins are considered joking relatives, a survival of pagan conditions, while parallel cousins are not, in spite of the preferred status accorded to this type of marriage.

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The pagans, upon conversion then, begin to practice a marriage which was formerly considered incestuous. As far as one can see this transition takes place smoothly and without conflict. It may be remarked, that pagans when stating the rule of clan exogamy did so in a matter-of-fact way. It will be recalled that the supposed clan of witches is said to be endogamous, so that the pattern of clan endogamy is not entirely foreign to the pagan Hausa. I can only record  208 that I did not attempt to elicit an emotional reaction to this ostensible incest situation and none was spontaneously offered to me when the subject was under discussion.

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